



ON THE WRITE LINE

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BUSINESS OF INDIA BASHING HAS TO BE COUNTERED WITH AGGRESSION

Next time, when some commentator or media person from overseas talk about the **silence of the Indian crowd** when India is not doing well, we should ask them why their supporters haven't come to cheer for their team.

Aryna Sabalenka lying prone on the court after winning the point that crowned her the US Open women's singles champion is a familiar sight, often seen from winners of any of the Majors. Yes, it's a tough grind over two weeks, and achieving victory must be a huge relief as well as joy for sure.

While it's common to see men lying flat on their backs after a win, female athletes like Sabalenka face criticism for doing the same. Every individual has a right to celebrate his/her win as they think fit, as long as it's within the confines of propriety. Sabalenka had been beaten in the final last year by Coco Gauff, an American, and here she was playing another American in the final.

The crowd was understandably rooting for the home girl, so the pressure was enormous on Sabalenka. Just before the semis against Emma Navarro, another American, she had jokingly told the crowd that the drinks would be on her if they gave her some support. She

didn't really need that in both the semis and the final, as she was miles better than her opponents and won quite comfortably.

This home support business is a natural thing, as nobody likes to see their country or country's player lose, especially in a sporting contest. Yet this support is invariably held against Indian crowds by overseas media and commentators. They quickly forget that even in their own country it is the same, and their crowds are hardly likely to support the opposition.

I can say with experience of more than 50 years that it's not just the Indian crowds who are silent when their team is not doing well but crowds in every country. If there is some noise when, say, India is doing well overseas, it's because of the number of Indian supporters who travel long distances from India and who cheer for them and not the locals.

So next time, when some commentator or media person from overseas tries to talk